

SINGLE PARENTS, BLENDED FAMILIES, ADOPTED KIDS: A FINANCIAL STRATEGY

Michelle Obama once referred to herself on national television as a single mom. It was an unintentional gaffe. Later, the First Lady clarified: “Sometimes, when you’ve got a husband who is president, it can feel a little single,” she said. “But he’s there.”

I can understand where she’s coming from. My mother, Georgette, was a single parent long before my father left. Terry was an old-style Irishman: he was out with his buddies, drinking and living a wild life. He was never home with his family. My mother had to be responsible not just for herself but also for her wayward husband and two young children. She wasn’t getting much in the way of support from Terry—financially or emotionally.

It’s an all-too-familiar story: the workaholic man pursuing success, often at the expense of time spent with his family. Or the professional woman climbing the corporate ladder, working day and night while her husband stays at home with the kids. In either scenario, the stay-at-home partner is essentially a single parent raising the kids.

To be honest, I spent several years MIA myself. When I was growing my first business, The Learning Company, my long-term